Second Door Reentry Network

Walking alongside neighbors coming home from incarceration

STATUS	501(c)(3) public charity, Connecticut
FOUNDED	2020
BASED IN	Dixwell, New Haven (shared office in a community center)
SERVES	Adults returning to Greater New Haven from prison or jail
ANNUAL BUDGET	About $240,000
STAFF	Executive director, 2 peer navigators (both formerly incarcerated), part-time admin
VOLUNTEERS	About 12 mentors
REACH	About 85 participants enrolled per year; 30–40 active at any time

MISSION

Second Door helps people coming home from incarceration rebuild stable lives, led by people who have walked that road themselves.

OUR STORY

Our founder came home in 2016 with a bus ticket and a trash bag of belongings. After years of informally helping friends get IDs and find work, she started Second Door with two other returning citizens. Peer leadership is our model: every navigator has lived experience.

WHO WE SERVE

Mostly men ages 25–55, many returning after sentences of three years or more. Many are on parole or probation. Common needs: ID documents, housing, work, reconnecting with family, and support for mental health and substance use.

PROGRAMS

First 72 Hours
A navigator meets participants on release day when possible, with a phone, a bus pass, clothing, and a plan for the first week.

Peer Navigation
Up to 12 months of one-on-one support: documents, benefits, housing referrals, job leads, court and parole appointments. Navigators carry 15–20 people each.

Tuesday Circle
A weekly peer support group with a meal. Open to anyone who's come home, at any point.

HOW WE'RE FUNDED

A state reentry services contract (40%), two foundation grants (35%), faith-community and individual donations (25%).

WHAT WE TRACK TODAY

The state contract requires quarterly counts of people served, IDs obtained, and job placements, which Second Door reports through the state's online form. Navigators keep notes in a shared drive. No data on housing stability or recidivism beyond what participants share.

WHAT WE'RE WRESTLING WITH

The state counts outputs, but foundation funders want outcomes like reduced reincarceration, which Second Door can't easily track. Staff worry that asking sensitive questions could damage the trust their model depends on.

A MOMENT FROM OUR WORK

A participant who had been inside for eleven years got his first state ID, opened a bank account, and started a warehouse job, all in one month. He now co-leads the Tuesday Circle. (Details changed to protect privacy.)